

Language THERAPY

When an American writer learns Hindi to discover her inner self



DREAMING IN HINDI: COMING AWAKE IN ANOTHER LANGUAGE
by KATHERINE RUSSELL RICH
Tranquebar
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 401

By Dilip Bobb

In American publishing, getting a favourable review from talk show queen Oprah Winfrey is the equivalent of an Oscar nomination for films, such is the cultural influence she commands. *Dreaming in Hindi* was on Oprah magazines' list of '10 Terrific Reads of 2009' and we now have the book's Indian edition. How it received such exalted status is as much a mystery as the author's decision to learn Hindi as a sort of spiritual journey of self-discovery and healing. It's very Western, this idea that India is where one needs to be to stumble across the meaning of life, but finding nirvana in grammar? It's a search that's a bit hard to follow, especially since the book tends to meander along like one of the sacred cows she encounters, stopping occasionally to disgorge some intellectual cud, and then moving on rather aimlessly in search of further sustenance.

Katherine Russell Rich is a former lifestyle magazine journalist who decided to move from New York to Udaipur to learn Hindi, inspired by a desire for learning a second language and understanding what such a process "does to the brain." The real inspiration has to be *Eat, Pray, Love*, a 2006 memoir by fellow American Elizabeth Gilbert which chronicled the author's extended trip after her divorce and what she discovered while on a gastronomic odyssey in Italy, finding spiritual sustenance in India and having love bite in Indonesia. It became a publishing phenomenon and is being made into a movie starring Julia Roberts who spent time recently in the same ashram in Haryana on which Gilbert based her India adventure. Rich,

having survived divorce, a bout with cancer and being fired from her editing job, says she "no longer had the language to describe my own life. So I decided to borrow someone else's."

It's an uncomfortable fit. She starts taking casual Hindi lessons in New York which blossom into an obsession with the language and the journey to Udaipur for encounters with royalty and commoners, gurus and charlatans, fellow students and teachers, secularists and communalists, while she struggles with idioms and grammar and punctuations. It pretty much describes the literary journey that the reader will perforce have to take, struggling to come to grips with the author's linguistic love affair. What works is that Rich has a highly readable writing style, wit and invites some degree of empathy in this part memoir part travelogue.

What doesn't work at all is the central thesis, that the mastery of a new, arcane language will make her a new person. There is very little self-revelation to support the theme. Indeed, Hindi is interesting to her, and presumably Oprah as well, as a slice of exotica, something quite static as opposed to a living, evolving language. Her India is strewn with stereotypes and Hindi phrases which lend nothing to the narrative. She comes across as a serious-enough student desperately trying to escape the traumas of her past without quite explaining what it is she gains by the end of it all. There are too

many random encounters and incidents, and far too many people in the book, leaving her sense of India and its language in literary limbo. There are external incidents—the horrific Gujarat riots for one, which punctuate the narrative but add little to its literary journey, much like hers to India. This is essentially narcissistic New Age reading which adds little to the author's reputation, or for that matter, to Oprah's literary tastes. ■



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